FT FollowThrough

The Car Detailing Playbook

What to say from the first call to the five-star review. Copy the lines, put them in your own words, and keep this on your phone.

1. The first call or message

Sound calm, understand the job, and book a next step. Ask:

- What's the car: a sedan, a small SUV, a three-row SUV or a truck?
- Inside, outside or both? Anything special, like pet hair, stains or smoke smell?
- What's bothering you about the paint: dull, swirls, scratches?
- Where would I work: your driveway, or is there water and power nearby?

> "Thanks for reaching out to [Business], this is [Name]. Tell me about the car and I'll see how we can help."

> "Can you text me a few photos, inside and out? I have Thursday at 9 or Saturday at 8 open. Which works better?"

2. Presenting the quote

- Price by vehicle size and package, and list what each package includes.
- Set fixed fees for pet hair, stains and heavy soil, and say the final price is confirmed when you see the car.
- Offer two or three packages: a maintenance wash, a full detail and paint correction or sealant.
- Explain your deposit and rescheduling policy when you book.

> "For your SUV, the full detail is [price] and includes [list]. If there's a lot of pet hair, that's [fee] extra, and I'll tell you before I start. Saturday at 8 still works?"

3. The 7 objections detailers hear and what to say

Acknowledge it, ask a question, answer honestly, suggest a next step.

1. "Another detailer quoted me $150."
"Could be a good deal, and prices do vary. What does theirs include? Ask whether it's a hand wash with clean mitts, clay and sealant, and real carpet extraction or just a vacuum. I'll send my package list so you can compare."

2. "I want to check a couple of other detailers."
"Good idea. What matters most to you, the paint or the interior? Ask each one for before-and-after photos of a car like yours and proof of insurance. I'll hold Saturday morning for you until Thursday."

3. "Can you knock something off?"
"I can fit a budget. What were you hoping to spend? I can do just the interior, or a wash and sealant instead of a full detail. What I won't do is rush the wash, because that's where swirl marks come from."

4. "I'll just take it through the car wash."
"That's quick, and fine between details. Have you noticed fine circles in the paint in direct sun? Brushes and dirty towels cause most of them. I can polish a test spot on your hood so you can see the difference before you decide."

5. "I'll wait until spring."
"Understood. Is the car parked outside this winter? Salt and grime left on the paint and in the carpet all season get harder to remove. A wash and sealant now protects it until spring, and I can book your full detail for April."

6. “What if you damage my car?”
“Fair question. What worries you most, the paint or the interior? I photograph the car before I start, test products on a hidden spot, and carry garagekeepers coverage for cars in my care. I’ll send the certificate before your appointment.”

7. “Why do you need a deposit to book?”
“Good question. Weekend slots fill fast, and a no-show costs me the whole morning. The deposit comes off your total, and you can move the booking free with 24 hours’ notice. Does that work for your schedule? I’ll send the booking link.”

4. Follow up: day 2, day 5, day 12

Most quotes go quiet, not “no”. Keep each message short and useful.

> **Day 2:** “Hi [Name], it’s [Your name] from [Business]. Did the package list come through okay? Happy to answer any questions.”

> **Day 5:** “Hi [Name], I have a spot open on [day] morning. Want me to hold it for your [car]?”

> **Day 12:** “Hi [Name], I’ll close out your quote on Friday. If you’d like just the interior for now, reply and I’ll fit you in.”

Most people won’t rebook unless you ask. Text every customer 4–6 weeks after a detail to book the next one.

5. Ask for the review and the referral

Ask during the final walk-around, when they see the car shine, and text a direct link to your Google review page.

> “Thanks again, [Name]. If you’re happy with the car, would you leave a quick Google review? Before-and-after photos help a lot. I’ll text you the link. And if a friend’s car needs some love, I’d be glad to help.”

Take before-and-after photos of every car (with the owner’s okay). They’re your best advertising on Google and social media.

Three rules that keep you out of trouble

- Carry garagekeepers coverage. General liability usually doesn’t cover damage to cars in your care.
- Photograph every panel, wheel and seat before you start, and note existing damage on the work order.
- Keep wash water out of storm drains, and check your city’s and state’s rules on water and on paying techs.

General education, not legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules and prices vary by state, so check yours.
The full start-up guide for detailers: followthroughguides.com/car-detailing · Questions: info@followthroughguides.com